JESSICA ROOD

Department of Economics, Rice University, Houston TX

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EDUCATION

PhD in Economics; fifth year. Expected 2028

Rice University, Houston, TX

- *Graduate First Year Fellowship*, 2022

Bachelor of Science in Economics May 2022

Minors in Mathematics and Political Science & International Relations. Cumulative GPA 4.0

Truman State University, Kirksville, MO.

- *Outstanding Student in Economics*, 2022

RESEARCH AND TEACHING INTERESTS

Primary: Labor Economics, Experimental Economics

Secondary: Family Economics

WORKS IN PROGRESS

- **"Beliefs, Attention, and Investments in Early Childhood"** with Flávio Cunha, Snejana Nihtianova, and Anja-Lize van der Merwe [NBER WP #35150]
- **"Turnover as a Barrier in Early Childcare Supports,"** with Ji-Hee Lee

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

W.E. Upjohn Institute, Kalamazoo, MI Summer 2026

AEA Summer Dissertation Fellowship

Texas Policy Lab/Kinder Institute for Urban Research, Houston, TX Summer 2023-Present

Graduate Research Assistant

Causal Inference: Economic Mobility Report

- Measuring what the 2015 oil-price collapse did to the conditions for economic mobility in Houston, via synthetic difference-in-differences across nine federal data sources;
- Built the study's full estimation pipeline and replication package; drafting the public-facing report

Project Management: Baby Sign Language Pilot Program

- Co-designed a randomized controlled trial to evaluate an existing 8-week baby sign language program's effects on caregiver-child bonding and child development outcomes;
- Engaged community partners to establish recruitment pipelines and program deployment;
- Built grant proposals to secure project funding

Experimental Research: LENA Start Program (RCT)

- Cleaned and merged device-recording and survey data from a 10-week Randomized Controlled Trial in Alief ISD administered over 5 years;
- Assessed sensitivity of OLS estimates to attrition and recording choice using balancing, IPW, and Lee Bounds;
- Implemented causal forests to estimate heterogeneous treatment effects

Policy Analysis: State Early Childcare Programs

- Contributed to qualitative data collection across three Texas state-run childcare support initiatives, conducting interviews and organizing program documentation;
- Co-developed codebooks and coded 90+ interviews alongside a four-person research team;
- Produced stakeholder-facing reports synthesizing program features and key findings, supported with direct quotes from interviews

American Institute for Economic Research, Great Barrington, MA Summer 2021
Summer Research Intern

- Assisted in development of a book chapter detailing a qualitative comparison of two counties, which highlighted the regulation relevant to micro-wind power;
- Collected data and generated figures for various research projects

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Rice University, Economics Department, Houston, TX, Fall 2025-Present
Teaching Assistant, Applied Econometrics (ECON 209)

- Designed and teach a new Python-based lab curriculum (Fall 2026, with Prof. Jeff Dominitz);
- Led recitations designed to support course content (introduction to RStudio and theoretical concepts);
- Graded problem sets, projects, and exams;
- Maintained flexible office hours to accommodate student schedules

Truman State University Economics Department, Kirksville, MO Spring 2020/2021
Teaching Assistant, Self & Society

- Developed and implemented interdisciplinary curriculum with Dr. Gillette;
- Spearheaded and oversaw classroom discussion and activities;
- Aided in the collection and assessment of assignments

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Good Reason Houston, Houston TX, October 2025 – January 2026
Research Consultant

- Analyzed data from a 900+ respondent caregiver survey on familiarity with and attitudes toward public pre-K in Houston, TX;
- Translated quantitative findings into focus-group design and a mixed-methods report for district stakeholders and the public

PRESENTATIONS & MENTORSHIP

- *Student Presenter,* "Inside the Production Function: Turnover and Public Investment in Early Childhood Education," APPAM Fall Research Conference, Boston, MA, 2026
- *Student Presenter,* "How Families Choose Child Care," CIISR Fellows Seminar, Rice University, Houston, TX, 2026
- *Student Presenter,* "Beliefs, Attention, and Investments in Early Childhood," Advances with Field Experiments Conference, University of Chicago, Chicago, IL, 2026

- *Student Presenter,* "Beliefs, Conversations, and Language Development in Early Childhood: Evidence and Mechanisms from an Experimental Study," Education Data Science Conference, Stanford University, 2026
- *Student Presenter,* "Beliefs, Conversations, and Language Development in Early Childhood: Evidence and Mechanisms from an Experimental Study," Association for Education Finance & Policy (AEFP), Chicago, IL, 2026
- *Student Poster Presentation,* "Exploring the Mechanisms of a Language-Based Parenting Intervention: Evaluation of the LENA Program," APPAM, Seattle, WA, 2025
- *Mentee,* APPAM Mentorship Program. Mentor: Matthew Stagner, 2025
- *Student Presenter,* "Beliefs, Conversations, and Language Development in Early Childhood: Evidence and Mechanisms from an Experimental Study", MidSouth Education Policy Workshop, Lexington, KY, 2025
- *Student Presenter,* "Exploring the Mechanisms of a Language-Based Parenting Intervention: An Evaluation of the LENA Start Program," Rice University's Third-Year Paper Conference, *Houston, TX,* 2025
- *Student Presenter*, "Exploring the Mechanisms of a Language-Based Parenting Intervention: An Evaluation of the LENA Start Program," Texas Applied Microeconomics Students Workshop (TEAMS), *College Station, TX,* 2025
- *Mentee,* CSWEP Mentoring Workshop, *Washington D.C.,* 2024

OTHER EXPERIENCE

Truman State University, Kirksville, MO

- Writing Consultant — Spring 2021/2022
- Math Tutor — Fall 2019

LEADERSHIP EXPERIENCE

Student Activities Board, Kirksville, MO — 2018-2022

President, Special Events Chair, External Affairs Representative

- Directed an event planning organization with a $475,000 budget during the COVID-19 pandemic;
- Collaborated with agents and University Administration to organize and contract complex events;
- Worked with other campus entities to promote transparency and communication

COCURRICCULAR ACTIVITIES

Graduate Economics Association, *Student Representative,* Rice University — 2024-Present
Cardinal Key Honor Society, *Parliamentarian,* Truman State University — 2020-2022

HONORS / AWARDS

Center for Computational Insights on Inequality and Society Research Fellowship ($1,500), 2026
SSRI Dissertation Research Improvement Grant ($5,000), 2026
Center for Computational Insights on Inequality and Society Research Grant ($1,899), 2026
Dagobert L. Brito Award for Best Performance by a Recitation Instructor, Spring 2026
AIER's Wesley G. McCain Scholarship in Honor of Murray Rothbard, 2022
Pi Sigma Alpha, 2020-2022
Truman State University President's List, 2018-2022
Harry S. Truman Leadership Scholar, 2018-2022

Gasconade County Math and Science Scholarship, 2018-2022
Missouri Bright Flight Award, 2018-2022

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming
Stata, Julia, Python, R (causal_forest), LaTeX
Data Collection and Management
Salesforce, ATLAS.ti, Qualtrics, Box, Square